

2018 A-level Paper 2 : Voting Among Millennials

Suggested Answer Scheme (*Examiners' Comments in italics*)

1. In paragraph 1, how does the author demonstrate that Alex Orlyuk is not living a life of 'political apathy'? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [3]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
He follows politics and prizes democracy. He thinks his government should do more to make peace with Palestinians, separate religion and state, and cut inequality. (l.3-5)	Orlyuk keeps abreast of/ takes an interest in/ is aware of political happenings, [1] cherishes/ values the democratic process [1] and is critical of his government's failings/ has many critiques of his government's policies/ believes that his government has several areas of improvement. [1]

Examiners' comments: Stronger responses showed careful reading of the wording of the question focus which was on the life that Alex Orlyuk is living now; therefore, details of his family's earlier struggles were not relevant. Many candidates saw this and produced succinct paraphrases of Alex's current attitude. Weaker responses either only paraphrased the earlier family history rather than how Alex feels today, or paraphrased everything in the first paragraph.

2. How does the author support their assertion that the voting behaviour of Israeli young people is 'all of a pattern with the rest of the rich world' (line 14)? [1]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
Although turnout has been generally declining across the rich world, it has fallen faster among the young. Recent evidence from Britain, Poland, Switzerland and America showed that more than half of millennials stayed at home on election day. (l.14-17)	The author cites evidence/ statistical data from other wealthy nations, showing that just like in Israel, a majority of young people did not vote. [1]

Examiners' comments: Stronger candidates recognised that the question was looking for the way in which the author substantiates his assertion, namely through the use of evidence. Weaker responses repeated, in differing forms, the idea mentioned in the question that the voting pattern of Israeli youth is akin to that shown elsewhere in similarly wealthy nations.

3. What does the author mean by the description of the young changing 'from a pivotal voting bloc into a peripheral one' (lines 20-21)? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
Demographic trends further weaken the political voice of the young.... As a result, the young will have dwindled from a pivotal voting bloc into a peripheral one... (l.17-21)	Previously, the impact/ influence of young people's votes on election results was significant. [1] However, this impact has eroded/ declined and is now insignificant/ unimportant. [1]

Examiners' comments: Stronger candidates saw that the change was a matter of the decline in the impact that young people's votes have on the final result in elections, not simply about the declining numbers of votes millennials are casting. An example of a strong response that demonstrated this was: 'the effect of the votes of the young has weakened from being an influential collective voice to one so enfeebled as to be on the sidelines'. Weaker responses focused on just one of the two terms – 'young voters used to be significant' – so that the decline in impact – the before and after – was not fully described.

4. Explain the author's use of the word 'presages' in line 22. [1]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
As a result, the young will have dwindled from a pivotal voting bloc into a peripheral one which raises the worrying possibility that today's record-low youth turnout presages a permanent shift. (l.20-22)	The author fears that the recent decline in youth turnout does not bode well/ is a bad omen , indicative of young people's irreversible diminished influence in future elections. [1]

Examiners' comments: Stronger candidates read the whole sentence in which the word 'presages' occurred and noted that earlier in the sentence the author suggested that the recent low turnout of young voters 'raises the worrying possibility' of this being an irreversible development: 'it does not auger well', as another candidate wrote. Weaker responses often missed this clear expression of the author's regret, even alarm, that this was the case; they simply said that what was presaged was that low voter turnout among young voters would become a permanent feature of future elections.

5. In paragraph 3, how does the author suggest that the attitudes of millennials towards voting may change in the future? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [3]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
Millennials are not the first young generation to be accused of shirking their civic duty. (l.26)	The author suggests that like their predecessors , the current generation may disprove assertions/ claims by elders that they are indifferent about voting and come to appreciate voting. [1]
People who have children and own a home feel more attached to their communities and are more concerned about how they are run. (l.31-32)	Those who become parents/ start their own families/ possess property experience greater affiliation with/ greater interest in the management of their societies. [1]
But youngsters are settling down later than their parents did. (l.31-32)	The current generation are establishing families at an older age than their predecessors, and hence will become interested in voting later. [1]

Examiners' comments: Most candidates were able to identify that the current generation of young voters were in fact very interested in political debates and issues. Weaker answers missed the implication that the current generation might act as previous generations did, namely be mistakenly thought by their elders to be uninterested in politics, but would defy predictions and play a full part in the political life of Israel. Stronger candidates understood the concept put forward by the author that young voters, marrying later than their predecessors, will shed their uninterested earlier attitude and come to appreciate the importance of voting, but will do so later: as one put it

'when these youths finally become parents then they will vote'. Many candidates misread this aspect of the text, thinking the author was saying that when millennials finally marry they will focus exclusively on their family and never bother to vote at all in the future.

6. In paragraph 4, what reason does the author suggest as to why 'Millennials do not see voting as a duty' (lines 33-34)? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
Rather, they regard it as the duty of politicians to woo them (l.34-35)	Millennials expect politicians to/ think that politicians have the responsibility/ obligation to pursue/ attract their votes.
They see parties not as movements deserving of loyalty (l.35-36)	They do not believe that parties are entitled to/ warrant their allegiance/ devotion/ support .
but as brands they can choose between or ignore (l.36-37)	They treat parties as products they can either select/ pick or disregard/ reject/brush off .
A system that demands they vote for an all-or-nothing bundle of election promises looks uninviting by comparison. (l.38-39)	They find voting for a fixed/ inflexible basket of election promises unpalatable .
	1-2 pts = 1m 3 pts = 2m

Examiners' comments: Most candidates found at least two, if not three, reasons for millennials not regarding voting as their forefathers did.

7. Explain what the author means by 'a cycle of neglect and alienation' (line 41). [2]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
Many disillusioned youngsters regard refusing to vote as a way to express dissatisfaction with the choices on offer. But abstention traps them in a cycle of neglect and alienation ... Young people, seeing a system that offers them little, are even more likely to tune out, which gives parties more reason to ignore them. (l.40-44)	Not voting causes young people to be caught in an endless/ recurring/ interminable process/ chain [1] of abandonment and isolation/ estrangement . [1]

Examiners' comments: Most candidates answered this question well. Stronger candidates offered a wide variety of effective explanations for both aspects of the quotation. Weaker answers often missed the 'alienation' part of the quote and focussed only on 'cycle'.

8. In paragraph 6, what distinctions does the author draw between the way in which old people and young workers are treated by some policies? [2]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
Australians aged over 65 pay no tax on income under \$24508; younger workers start paying tax at \$15650. (l.48-49)	The elderly start paying taxes at a higher income threshold than young people. [1]
In Britain, free bus passes, television licenses and energy subsidies for pensioners have survived government cutbacks; housing assistance for young workers has not. (l.49-50)	The elderly have retained various benefits that they enjoy even though the young's have been cut by reductions in government spending. [1]
Young workers pay taxes toward health-care and pension schemes that are unlikely to be equally generous by the time they retire. (l.50-51)	Through their taxes, young people pay for the elderly's current benefits, but will not receive the same benefits when they become old. [1]

Examiners' comments: Most candidates successfully found at least two examples of the young being unfairly treated by various governments compared to how the elderly fared. Weaker responses misread the reference to inequity in taxation, thinking that the author was saying that the elderly in Australia did not pay any taxes at all, rather than that they began paying tax at a higher income threshold than their younger compatriots.

9. Using material from paragraphs 7-9 only (lines 53-74), summarise what the author has to say about the positive and negative effects of the strategies used to persuade more young people to vote.

Write your summary **in no more than 120 words**, not counting the opening words which are printed below. **Use your own words as far as possible.** [8]

One positive effect is ...

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
a. The most obvious would be to make voting compulsory (l.54)	that making voting mandatory/ obligatory
b. ... such a move would be ' transformative ' (l.56)	would cause great change ,
c. ... boosting the voices of the young and the poor (l.56-57)	enhancing/ increasing the ability of the young and poor to express their opinions .
d. But it could be argued that such a move would artificially boost turnout (l.57)	But this might unnaturally increase/ enhance turnout
e. ... without dealing with the underlying causes (l.58)	without tackling/ solving the root/ fundamental issues.
f. ... the priority should be to inspire a feeling among young people (l.59)	Stimulating/ encouraging a belief/ attitude among young people
g. ... 'that the system listens to you and reacts to you' (l.59-60)	that the government pays attention to/ takes heed of you and responds to you

h. ... which in turn would strengthen political commitment (l.60)	would reinforce/ bolster political engagement .
i. Teenagers who experience democracy first-hand during their studies (l.61-62)	Young people who encounter/ undergo the democratic process in school
j. ... are more likely to vote afterwards (l.62)	have a greater probability of voting than those who do not.
k. Student elections make young people feel they have the power (l.62-63)	Student elections make young people feel they have the ability/ capacity
l. ...to shape the institutions around them (l.63)	to influence/ mould the institutions around them.
m. Civic-education curricula which involve open discussions and debates (l.64)	Civic-education curricula which involve frank/ honest dialogues/ conversations/ exchanges
n. ... are better at fostering political engagement in later life (l.64-65)	are better at nurturing/ cultivating political engagement in adulthood
o. ... than classes dedicated to imparting facts about government institutions (l.65-66)	than lessons dedicated to transmitting/ conveying facts about government institutions.
p. Yet schools and governments, wary of accusations of politicising the classroom (l.66-67)	But schools and governments, cautious/ careful of allegations/ claims of politicising the classroom
q. ... may shy away from such programmes (l.66-67)	may avoid/ be unwilling to/ be reluctant to hold such programmes.
r. Another option would be to allow people to vote even younger (l.68) OR ... lowering the minimum age (l.71)	Reducing the required age for voting
s. In many countries, voting habits are formed during a particularly unsettled period of young people's lives (l.68-69)	(Inferred) would help ensure that voting habits are not developed during an exceptionally unstable/ uncertain time/ duration of young people's lives:
t. ... the few years after leaving school (l.68-70)	(Inferred) the few years after graduating .
u. ... ingrain voting habits earlier (l.70-71)	It would establish/ entrench voting habits at a younger age .

v. This lets young people cast their first votes (l.71-72)	and let young people register/ enter their first votes
w. ... while still in school and living with their parents (l.72)	..while they are still studying and staying with their parents.
x. In Austria, the only European country to let 16- and 17-year-olds vote nationwide, they have proved more likely than 18- to 20-year-olds to turn out in the first election for which they qualify to vote (l. 72-74)	(Inferred) Those who are younger have a greater probability of voting./ It would lead to greater turnout at the elections among young people.

24 possible points

(1-2pts = 1m, 3-4pts = 2m, 5-6pts = 3m, 7-8pts = 4m, 9-10pts = 5m, 11-12pts = 6m, 13-14pts = 7m, 15pts and more = 8m)

Examiners' Comments: Many candidates demonstrated strong summarising skills. The 120-word limit was scrupulously adhered to by all but a handful of candidates, and key words and phrases in the original were accurately rendered in the candidates' own words: for example, 'compulsory' was often rendered well as 'mandatory' or 'obligatory'. That said, it is not necessary to rephrase everyday terms: one candidate substituted 'school' with 'an infrastructure designed for learning' and another replaced 'living with their parents' with 'co-habiting with progenitors'.

Candidates' selection of material was almost invariably methodical and accurate; the exception being the occasional omission of the school context which was essential to score the points in paragraph 8. Many candidates employed a variety of suitable discourse markers, which contributed greatly to the flow of the final summary.

10. In paragraph 10, how does the author counter their earlier claim that Alex Orlyuk's attitude is one of 'disaffection' (line 9)? [1]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
Mr Olyuk fondly recalls Yitzhak Rabin (a former Israeli prime minister who was assassinated when Mr Olyuk was seven) for 'trying to make a change' by making peace with Palestinians. 'I'm still waiting for another Rabin to come along. Then I'll vote,' he says.	The author suggests that Olyuk's detachment from voting is temporary as he holds high standards and will only vote when the right candidate appears. [1]

Examiners' comments: Stronger candidates identified that, having begun the passage with a description of Alex Orlyuk's lack of enthusiasm for voting in the current political climate in Israel, the author ends the piece by suggesting Orlyuk's abstention from voting may well be only temporary, as he will vote if and when the right candidate from his point of view – someone in the mould of the late Yitzhak Rabin – comes onto the political scene. Weaker responses did not understand the term 'disaffection'.

(Disaffection: a state or feeling of being dissatisfied, especially with people in authority or a system of control.)

11. The author argues that young people 'are more interested in issues and causes than they are given credit for' (line 27).

How far do you agree or disagree with this view? Illustrate your answer by referring to the extent to which you, and young people within your society, are involved in issues and causes. [10]

Key Idea from passage: (They) are better educated than past generations are more likely to go on a protest or to become vegetarian, and are less keen on drugs and alcohol... (1.27-29)

Agree:

- Most young Singaporeans are especially connected to the Internet and social media, and are hence more keenly aware of the latest issues and causes, both locally and abroad. They also use social media as a way to communicate, debate and organise on such issues. Examples of this include the frequent discussion of political issues on platforms like Reddit and Twitter.
- Most young Singaporeans are actually more proactive in showcasing their political leanings and interests compared with the older generation. They are more disillusioned with the state of the world today and how Singapore is progressing, feel that they are disadvantaged compared to their parents, and do not feel the same allegiance to the state that previous generations did.
- Most young Singaporeans are more socially liberal and supportive of civil liberties than previous generations. Surveys have proven these attitudes, including greater support for the LGBT community, and awareness of racial and social issues in Singapore. This contrasts against Singapore's relative social conservatism.
- Most young Singaporeans are taking the initiative in driving social and political causes, from incorporating elements of environmental conservation into their mandatory Project Work to attending Pink Dot and championing LGBT rights. The most dedicated will even organise their own Service Learning activities to assist communities and interests they are particularly passionate about.

Disagree:

- Most young Singaporeans are still largely apathetic, and disengaged from current affairs. They prefer to discuss leisure activities like travelling, eating, gaming and watching movies. This can be seen in how the vast majority of social media content generated at this target audience covers these areas. Despite being vaguely aware of some political events, they choose to largely ignore them, believing it does not affect them.
- Most young Singaporeans are largely clueless when it comes to politics, due to the relative stability and political stagnation in Singapore's political scene compared with other countries. There has never been a need for them to actively campaign for their rights due to their relative privilege. Therefore, there has not been a need to aggressively question or even challenge the status quo.
- Most young Singaporeans are too busy and tired to be involved in issues and causes. They are burdened and overworked, be it in their teens with schoolwork or in adulthood with an increasingly competitive and unbalanced work life. With how taxed they are and how much time work takes up, they have little time or energy to concern themselves with much else.
- Most young Singaporeans, much like the previous generations, are more socially and politically pragmatic than the rest of the world. While they might believe in certain causes or issues, this is overridden by practical considerations on how this affects their standard of living, including security, earnings and stability. They are therefore more subdued in engaging with causes than they otherwise would be.
- Most younger Singaporeans do not genuinely care about issues and causes, only participating in them if their school or employer obliges them to, or cynically taking part if they believe it makes them look good on their resume or among their peers. The societal emphasis on affective education and social awareness might push people to pad their portfolios or take part in organised activities, but it is ineffective in instilling genuine values.

Examiners' Comments:

This year's topic proved to be engaging, leading to many energetic and well-argued responses. Stronger responses picked out relevant aspects of the author's argument and subjected them to intelligent examination and evaluation. Some candidates were confused by the use of the word 'credit' in the text and question. Stronger candidates knew that to be 'given credit for' something is to have one's efforts acknowledged, respected and praised. However, a significant number of candidates interpreted it as one being given 'credits', i.e. some sort of certificated academic or even financial reward for one's action, and went on to describe how it was possible to achieve these, which proved a more restricted and restricting subject to write about.

Some candidates proudly trumpeted the actions of young Singaporeans like Ang Zyn Yee and her campaign against the menace of plastic straws, placing her campaign in the context of increasing concern about environmental damage both locally and globally. Other candidates wrote of their personal support and engagement with initiatives in the fields of mental health, disadvantaged children and the treatment of immigrants to demonstrate how millennials like themselves were volunteering to help others less fortunate. But, by far the most oft-quoted phenomenon was the Pink Dot campaign and the whole issue of Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual and Transgender (LGBT) rights. Strong responses suggested that such a campaign was heavily dependent on modern technology: thanks to mobile phones and social media, young Singaporeans are well-informed about such movements around the world and developments in their own country, and instantaneously spread the word about meetings and petitions ensuring a high turnout at events. Additionally such actions were often contextualised by being seen against the backdrop of a conservative society.

Weaker responses often took the approach of simply listing several examples of, in this case, issues and causes adopted by the young, and tended to be very descriptive in nature. These responses could have been improved by focusing on a small number of such causes, then subjecting each to as detailed an analysis as possible, accounting for its genesis, its purpose, its reception by the community at large, and its value, or its degree of success or otherwise. A further approach seen in some of the weaker responses was to quote a part of the text and then say 'What the author is trying to say is...' followed by a lengthy paraphrase of the text material. This approach limited the candidates' ability to evaluate the merits or otherwise of the opinions expressed in the text.

Regarding Use of English, a notable weakness in several scripts, was the absence of capital letters for proper nouns, for example, in 'ministry of education' or, by far the commonest of all, 'singapore'. Redundant prepositions were regularly seen, as in 'discuss about', 'voice out' and 'emphasise on'. Most candidates demonstrated an impressive command of grammar and punctuation, with their spelling, as ever, being almost perfect. The strongest scripts used a wide range of sophisticated vocabulary and showed confident handling of idiom throughout, such as 'plucked out of thin air' or 'passed with flying colours'. Candidates' strong paragraphing skills, supplemented by the use of a range of appropriate discourse markers, ensured the fluency and clarity of their writing.